I-Corps Workbook: Week 1

Solid hypotheses lead to more efficient customer discovery by narrowing your focus to a few key things you are trying to learn. At the end of this activity, you will have hypotheses on the problem you are trying to solve, the customer segment you are going to interview first, and your value proposition for those customers.

Remember: What makes a good hypothesis?

- It's a statement, not a question
- It can be proven false (i.e. we already know people want safety and profits; try to quantify your hypothesis to get more specific)
- Test your riskiest assumption first (what needs to be true in order for your idea to have a market)

Step 1) Refine the problem you're trying to solve! (~5 minutes)

Consider the following questions:

- What are the pains or frustrations of the customer, whether technical or emotional?
- What are the obstacles that prevent the problem from being solved?
- What are the undesired outcomes that result when the problem isn't fixed?

List the top 3 problems you are trying to solve below:

1.
2.
3.

Select the most "pants-on-fire" type of problem that really, really needs to be solved ASAP. The more specific, the better.

The biggest problem that my customer has is _____.

Step 2) Who has the problem? (~5 minutes)

Consider the following:

- Who needs your help? PEOPLE! Actual humans. Not buildings, not institutions.
- State specific activities or traits, not demographics – your customer is not "everyone", "women," or "doctors"
- **If you are selling to someone within a business**, what employee cares the most about the problem you are trying to solve?
    - What type and size of company do they work for? How many clients do they serve?
    - What is their job title? What job functions do they perform?

Fill in the blanks below with your selected customer and their biggest problem:

My customer, _____ (state your specific customer segment), has a problem and it is that _____ (state the customer's problem).

Review the various roles a customer could play:

- End user – person who will use your product
- Decision maker – can authorize purchase
- Economic buyer – actually writes you the check
- Influencers – people the decision maker might consult before making the decision
- Saboteur – influencer who undermines your solution
- Recommender – person who is paid to tell the decision maker what they think (like a consultant)

What role(s) does your customer play? _____

Step 3) What value would you create for this customer by solving this problem? (~5 minutes)

The best value proposition statements are singular in value and relate back to the singular problem. Your value proposition should:

- State the benefit **from the customers' point of view**
- Be **one value**, not a bunch of things strung together
- Be **specific**, and quantify the value if possible
- Be uniquely delivered by your team; **different** from the way competitive solutions solve the problem

My customer, _____ (state your customer segment), has a problem and it is that _____ (state the customer's problem).

The value my customers will receive when my solution solves their problem is _____ (state what a customer gets when they use your solution).

BONUS: The customer cannot receive this value from competitor's solutions because _____ (explain where competitor's solutions fall short).

FINAL CHECK: What makes a good hypothesis?

- It's a statement, not a question
- It can be proven false (i.e. we already know people want safety and profits; try to quantify your hypothesis to get more specific)
- Test your riskiest assumption first (what needs to be true in order for your idea to have a market)

If your hypothesis passes the check, then you are ready to test it in customer interviews! This is your chance to determine **if your ideal customer actually experiences the problem.**

Sign-up for a Week 2 meeting slot before leaving today's session!